

## WHAT ARE AUM CERTIFICATES?

- The 'Aum Standards Certificate' seeks to certify that prasad/ puja material sold in pilgrimage centres is 'pure'
- It is being sold as the Hindu equivalent of the Halal certificate, which is issued to certify that a food product conforms to Islamic beliefs
- It has been issued to 150 shops/ eateries in Trimbakeshwar by the Aum Pratisthan, a Hindu organisation registered as a not-for-profit company
- They have also been given to Nashik establishments and around 25 Mumbai restaurants

Kaal and Amavasya.

Secular activists like those from the anti-superstition group Maharashtra Andhashradda Nirmulan Samiti (MANS), launched by the slain rationalist Dr Narendra Dabholkar, see the whole affair as an economic apartheid against Muslims. Savarkar is unabashed about his intent. Pointing out how there are no Hindu-owned shops outside masjids, he says: "This (selling of puja material) is considered *kufr* (lack of faith) in their religion." Endorsing his viewpoint is Sunil Ghanwat, coordinator of the Maharashtra Mandir Mahasangh. "This is a *prasad shuddhi chalwal* (a movement for the purity of prasad) to ensure that *vidharmis* (non-Hindus) do not sell adulterated prasad near temples," he says.

"The Aum certificate is being issued to further widen the social cleavage," says Sadruddin Kokni, president of the Trimbakeshwar Muslim Samaj. "Muslim communities like the Attars and Maniars have traditionally sold puja material to Hindu devotees."

Others ask how the Pratisthan has taken it upon itself to test prasad, as that is the responsibility of the state food and drug administration (FDA). Dharmaraobaba Atram, FDA minister, has said that only they have the authority to collect food samples for checking. "If this religious purity logic is to be accepted, then its proponents must check in whose farms the lentils and raisins used in the prasad are grown," says Purushottam Kadlag, a temple trustee and working president of the NCP's (Sharadchandra Pawar) youth wing.

On his part, Savarkar says they are not testing any samples. "The FDA will test standards while we will verify religious purity by checking who made and sold the sweets used as offerings," he says. And there is no mistaking who will fail this test of religious purity. ■

**–Dhaval S. Kulkarni**

tion cases in the past—Jagan Reddy cites figures to say 14 tankers were rejected during the earlier TDP regime (2014-19) and 18 during his term (2019-24)—Naidu's claim about animal fat was unprecedented and had shocked temple officials. In fact, TTD authorities had rejected four tankers of ghee provided by one of the suppliers, AR Dairy Foods Private Ltd, Dindigul, Tamil Nadu, just recently in July (the other ghee suppliers now are Premier Agri Foods, Kriparam Dairy, Vaishnavi, Sri Parag Milk, Alpha Diary and the Karnataka Milk Federation who makes Nandini brand ghee). Incidentally, the show cause notice now issued to AR Dairy only alleges adulteration with plant-based oils, citing the presence of a plant sterol, β-sitosterol, and makes no mention of any animal fats in its ghee consignment.

**WHILE THE NDDB REPORT SAYS THE GHEE SAMPLE IS ADULTERATED, IT DOES NOT SPECIFICALLY SAY THAT ANIMAL FAT WAS THE CONTAMINANT**

### TWEAK IN THE TENDER

TTD sources say that the temple authorities are very particular about quality, and source ghee and the other materials used to make laddoos through e-tenders. Officials claim they have scarcely veered away from tradition. Even today, Tirupati laddoos are made in the temple kitchen, called 'potu', and located in the inner tier of the temple, on the left side of the sanctum sanctorum. The raw materials are transported to the kitchen on conveyor belts. The laddoos are prepared as per "*dittam*" (proportion), with a list of ingredients mentioned in the Agama shastras (the manuals of worship laid down for temple buildings and rituals). At present, some 300,000 laddoos are prepared every day, with some 600